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Dude, Where's My Data?

Terabytes of data and not one bit to be found? Here's a self-help guide to efficient data hoarding and smarter data management

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We download and exchange data everyday. Here, we will introduce software methods to better manage the physical space and the myriad of forms that data can take. We will take a look at hard disk partitioning, spanning data over hard drives, OS features to better represent your data, and briefly touch upon software for cataloguing media, searching for media, and so on. While this has been written specifically for Windows XP, you can apply the same general principles to Linux as well.

Divide And Conquer

Today, an 80 GB hard disk is the norm. 120 GB hard disks, too, are cheap enough to consider. With drives touching these sizes, partitioning becomes important: first off, Windows XP only requires a certain amount of space, and allocating about 7 GB for Windows is comfortable enough for the OS. We also recommend moving the Program Files folder (where all your non-OS software is stored) to a different partition. The biggest positive of such a separation is reduction of disk fragmentation: with a big hard drive, fragmentation becomes more pronounced, especially as you add and remove programs in the course of daily use. Storing all your data on a single 80 or 120 GB volume will only exacerbate disk and file fragmentation. By keeping your

programs separate from your OS, you minimise overall fragmentation, make defragmentation much easier, improve disk efficiency and speed, and keep things neat and tidy for OS reinstalls. Another benefit is that you can delete just your Windows install while keeping your program data and documents intact.

Moving The My Documents Folder

XP has a bunch of folders it terms shell folders, which store a certain type of data. Apart from the Program Files folder we've been speaking of, you have your My Documents, My Music, My Videos, Documents and Settings, and so on. The content of these folders is apparent, and both XP and programs running on XP use these default locations to their benefit. What we

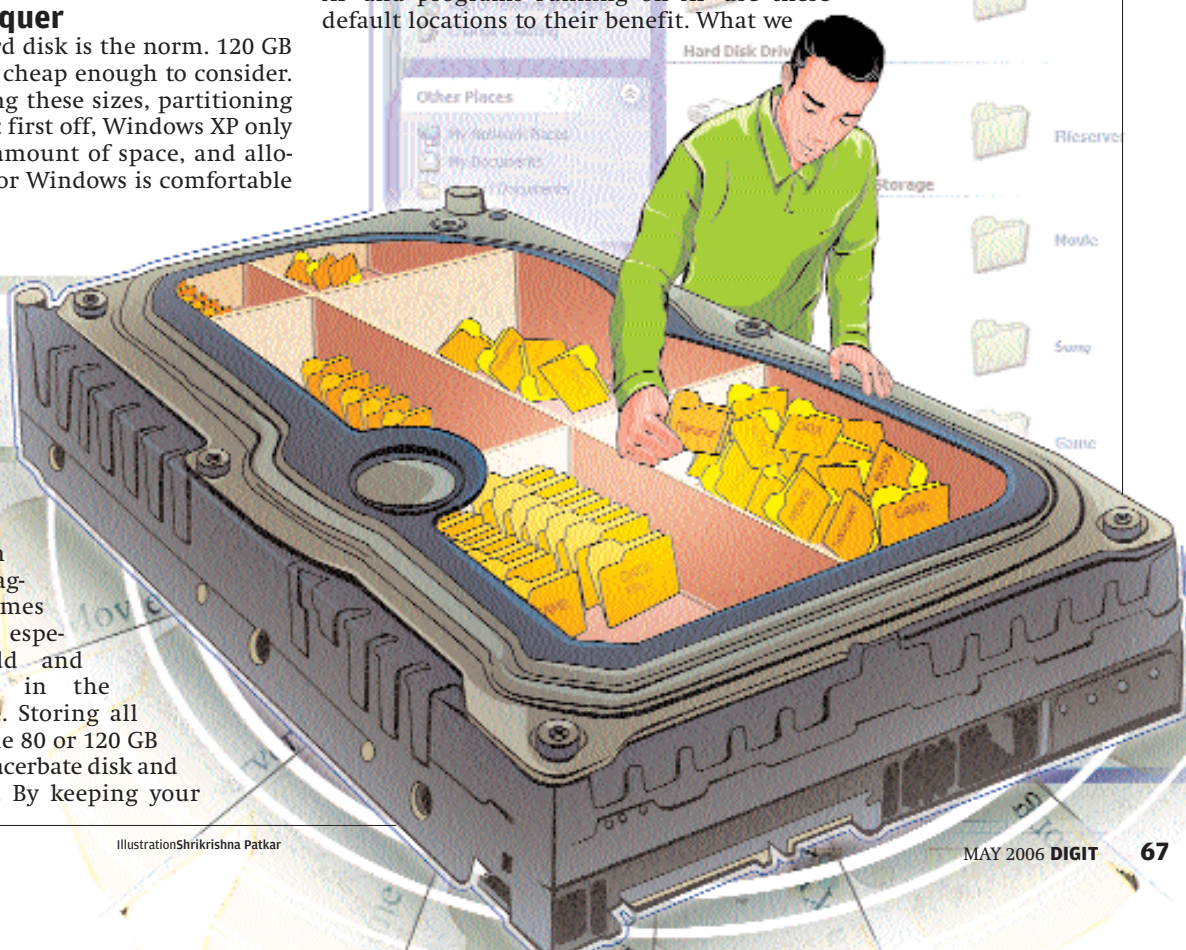


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